

University of Westminster

School of Computer Science and Engineering

Information Driven Entrepreneurship and Enterprise

Group Assignment

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1. Business Idea Analysing and Feasibility	3
1.1. Business idea overview	3
1.2. E-business categorisation and business model	3
1.3. Rich Picture	4
1.4. Pitch Video (link)	4
1.5. Competitive Analysis	4
2. Strategic Business Analysis	5
2.1. Porter's Five Forces	5
2.2. SWOT Matrix analysis	7
2.3. PESTEL analysis	7
2.4. Additional Technique: Lean Canvas	9
2.5. Summary of Business Strategy	9
3. User requirements and System Design Specification	10
3.1. User Requirements	10
Functional Requirements	10
Non-Functional Requirements	11
3.2. Use Case Diagram	12
3.3. Use Case Description	12
3.4. Additional Technique: Activity diagrams	13
Activity Diagram for Register Account	14
Activity Diagram for Manage Profile	15
Activity Diagram for Manage Subscription	15
Activity Diagram for Manage Account	16
Activity Diagram for Login	17
Activity Diagram for Search Users	18
Activity Diagram for Manage Connections	18
Activity Diagram for View Feed	19
Activity Diagram for Manage Activities	20
Activity Diagram for Create & Manage Posts	20
Activity Diagram for Send Messages	21
4. Individual roles in the business, group mentoring – max 300 words (10 marks)	21
Eesa Batan	21
Sri Ganesan	22
Pawel Krezel	22
Alexandra Marin	23
Brenda Ojatamm	23
Ryan Rahman	24
Appendix	24
Records of collaboration and discussions	24
AI Declaration	25
References	25

1. Business Idea Analysing and Feasibility

1.1. Business idea overview

Our proposed business is a subscription-based digital-minimalist social platform Link.ly, delivered through a website and mobile app built for people who want real connection. The platform is designed to support intentional social interaction by enabling friend-only posting, private messaging, and optional local discovery. Unlike mainstream platforms, Link.ly's feed is chronological and limited to connections the user chooses, and it avoids features designed to maximise time spent on the app, such as suggested posts and infinite scroll. This approach reflects growing regulatory pressure to give users lasting control over how feeds are shown and a Dutch court has ordered Meta to keep non-profiled timelines and to stop switching users back to algorithmic feeds, describing the design as a "dark pattern" that reduces user choice (Reuters, 2025).

Target Market and Audience

The primary target segment is UK university students (18–26) studying away from home and early-career remote workers (22–34) who prioritise privacy, autonomy, and purposeful online communication. This includes people experiencing transition, such as relocating to new cities within the UK, international students in the UK, travelling in the UK, or working remotely. They are privacy-conscious and already using WhatsApp/Instagram but dissatisfied with recommendation feeds, too many applications and recommendation feeds.

Generating Revenue

Revenue would come from monthly and annual subscriptions, which aligns the business incentive with user experience rather than attention capture. This approach is supported by evidence that UK spending on digital content and subscriptions has increased since 2020, although consumers remain selective and value-sensitive (Barclays, 2025).

Mission Statement

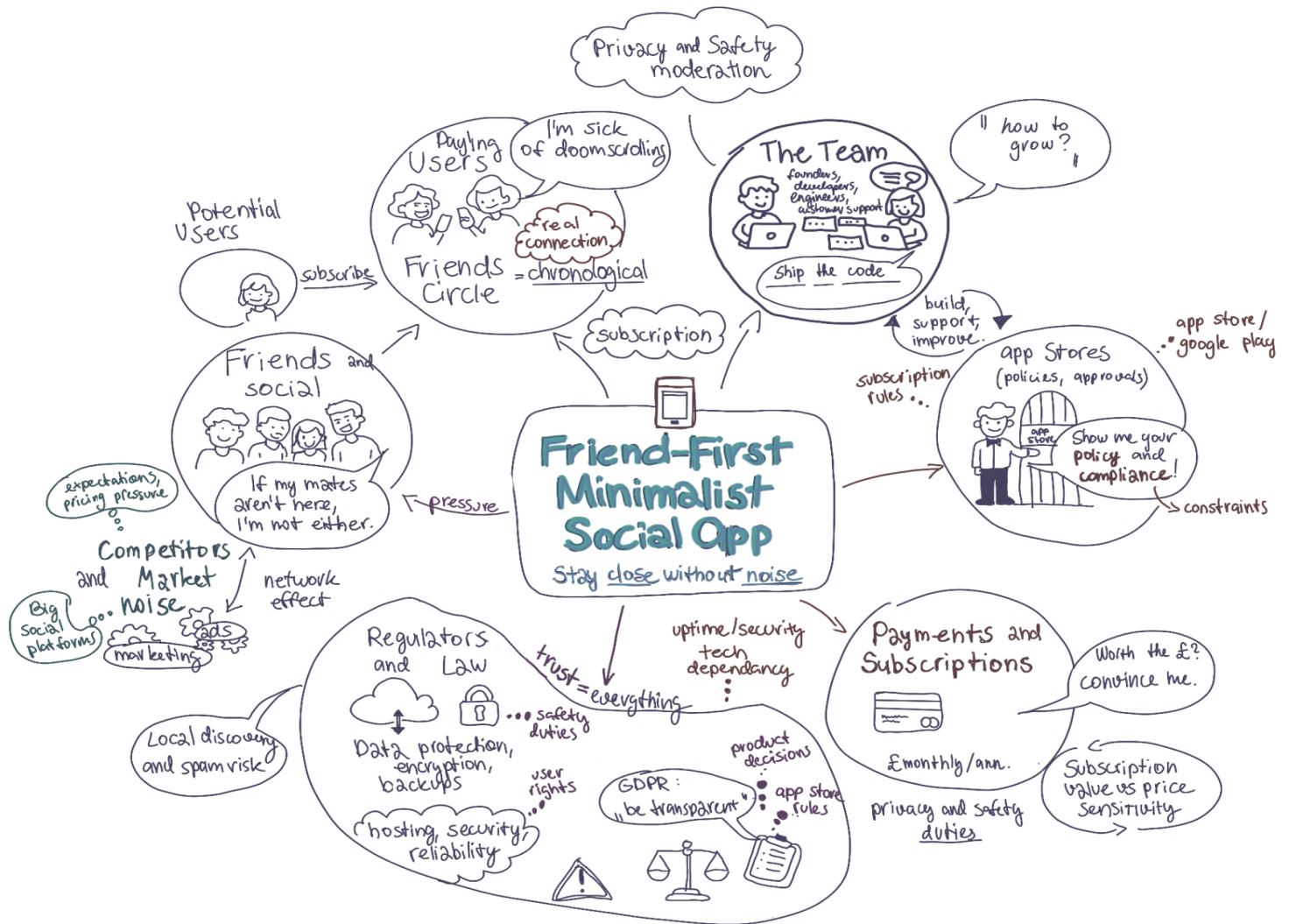
To help people stay close without noise by enabling real connection in a friend-first social space.

1.2. E-business categorisation and business model

The proposed platform can be described as a **dotcom e-business** because its operations, service delivery, and customer interaction are conducted primarily online via a website or a mobile application, with no requirement for physical storefronts. The internet is central to how value is created and delivered. This venture sits in **pure e-commerce**, since the "product" is access to a digital social networking and messaging service, user onboarding and payments occur digitally, and the service is delivered digitally through the platform.

In terms of participant classification, it is primarily B2C because the company sells subscriptions directly to individual consumers.

1.3. Rich Picture



1.4. Pitch Video (link)

Link to the pitch video can be found under the following link:

https://youtu.be/49RUmkQ24dY?si=dcTta_1sRkzvQOOK

1.5. Competitive Analysis

Competitor	MeWe	SpaceHey	Bluesky/AT Protocol Apps	Facebook's 'Friends' Tab (a feature)
Positioning	- Privacy-first, ad-free social network (web + mobile) - Friends-first connections with chronological feed	- MySpace-style social platform (web login + mobile) - Claims no algorithms/tracking; early-web feel	- User-controlled feeds; lighter timelines - Public/broadcast social	- Feature reflects demand for friends-only experiences
Key Features	- Friend connections	- Friends - Messages	- Chronological "Following" feed	- Friends-only feed area inside Facebook

	- Groups - Messaging - Chronological feed	- Community-driven profiles/interaction	- option - Optional custom feeds made by third parties - Public conversation + wider audiences	
Business Model	- Freemium; paid tier \$4.99/month - Paid add-ons (e.g., stickers)	Mix of: - Merchandise - Direct community support - Advertising	- Domain sales - Potential premium features	- Ad-funded; targeted advertising incentives - Engagement-maximising design
Strengths	- Clear privacy-first branding - Familiar social features without heavy recommendation focus	- Aligns closely with the retro, community-first experience Link.ly is targeting - Strong identity and nostalgia appeal	- High user control and flexibility - Appeals to people who dislike heavy algorithmic timelines	- Huge existing user base - Confirms mainstream interest in “friends-first” modes
Weaknesses /Risks	- Limited mainstream visibility - Uneven experience due to inconsistent activity/content quality - Content can feel random (niche political spaces; unrelated languages)	- Unavailable in the UK due to Online Safety Act compliance	- Not primarily friend-first	- Still driven by ads + algorithms overall - Facebook’s still widely ad- and algorithm-driven, the experience isn’t the platform’s core focus - Only available in the US/Canada
How Link.ly gains advantage	- Stronger onboarding to reduce friction - User controls for language and discovery to prevent irrelevant content - Simple, non-intrusive monetisation (avoid upsells/add-ons)	- Offer “SpaceHey-style” experience that is UK-compliant - Build proportionate age assurance + child-safety controls from the start	- Serve a different need for friend-first connection	- Funded by subscriptions, so our product isn’t designed to chase attention for ad revenue. - Clear governance and consistent product promise - Responsive moderation/support than big platforms

2. Strategic Business Analysis

2.1. Porter's Five Forces

Porter's Five Forces was chosen to assess how attractive the UK social-platform market is and where Link.ly will feel the most strain.

Threat of New Entrants: Moderate

Building a platform is no longer the difficult part, AI coding assistants can make developers around 21% faster (Nguyen & Nadi, 2024). The harder part is getting attention and keeping people active, because users rely on dominant platforms daily, with WhatsApp being used by 80% of internet users and Instagram by 39% (Ofcom, 2024). This means people test new apps while using existing ones, which eases launching and competing for the same attention. Link.ly can reduce this risk by focusing on niche users who want a non-algorithmic, wellbeing-focused experience. Building strong community norms and user loyalty will make switching costs less attractive.

Rivalry Among Existing Competitors: High

Biggest platforms can copy popular ideas quickly (Meta's Facebook Friends tab shows only friends' content), and competition is also for attention and discovery. SpaceHey shows there is demand for a simpler, friends-first experience, but its UK shutdown highlights that regulation and safety duties can limit which similar services can operate in this market (SpaceHey, 2025). Rather than competing for mass adoption, Link.ly will target a specific audience, prioritising safety and compliance from launch can also build trust as an advantage.

Threat of Substitute Products: Moderate

Many people already achieve the same outcomes (chatting privately, sharing with a close circle, finding communities, and discovering local updates) using free alternatives. WhatsApp alone has 3B+ monthly users, making it a strong substitute, while Instagram's Close Friends feature and community spaces like Discord/Reddit cover other features (TechCrunch, 2025). Link.ly's opportunity is to reduce friction, so users don't have to manage multiple apps. Link.ly can reduce substitution combining chronological feed and posting limits to create an experience that mainstream platforms don't offer.

Bargaining Power of Buyers: High

Consumers can meet needs using free and familiar services, so switching costs are low. Charging a subscription in a market conditioned to free social products increases price pressure and churn risk. However, for Link.ly's users, willingness to pay can be higher if the product delivers a wellbeing benefit after free trial/first renewal, which'll help showcase value before subscription commitment.

Bargaining Power of Supplier: Moderate

The web app mainly depends on hosting and payment providers, which are usually easy to switch, but the mobile app will later add reliance on Apple/Google distribution and payment rules (Apple Developer, n.d.; Google, n.d.). To mitigate, we'll start with web subscriptions and keep more than one payment option, which reduces dependence on a single supplier.

Overall, Link.ly enters a high-pressure environment, where users can satisfy most social media needs using free, familiar apps, so buyer power and churn risk are high. The platform's viability depends on making the subscription feel justified through a free trial and then retaining users through a

minimalistic experience. Link.ly isn't competing for mass adoption and will win in a narrow segment that actively values digital minimalism and privacy.

2.2. SWOT Matrix analysis

SWOT analysis was chosen to convert research into strategy by summarising the internal strengths/weaknesses and external opportunities/threats that would help prioritise actions.

Our Organisation (Link.ly)	Strengths 1. Position as a minimalist app 2. No algorithms = reducing spread of misinformation 3. Subscription-based model	Weaknesses 1. Subscriptions limit quick user acquisition 2. Low brand recognition 3. Little value until friend network increases
Opportunities 1. Market for digital minimalism apps 2. Distrust and privacy issues between existing platforms 3. Partnerships with universities and well-being organisations	SO strategies Heavily position and market non-algorithmic feed to engage new digitally minimalist users (S2,O1) Reinvesting revenue from partnerships to create discounted packages for students (S3,O3)	WO strategies Providing free trials to encourage adoption (S1,O1) partnerships with universities to create word-of-mouth interactions for awareness and recognition (W2,O3)
Threats 1. Large competitors imitating features 2. Price-sensitive consumers due to economic pressure 3. Slow adoption	ST strategies Create differentiation through strong identity based on values to minimise imitation by competitors (S1,T1)	WT strategies Invest and create strong brand to position as original digital minimalist platform before competitors (W2,T1)

2.3. PESTEL analysis

PEST analysis captures wider macro-environment highlighting external conditions identifying opportunities and challenges affecting Link.ly's growth.

Political

UK online safety act 2023 regulations ensure social platforms implement strong content moderation for user-to-user services, even with a friend-first design, because users can connect with strangers sharing harmful content through posts and messaging. From July 2025, online services have a legal duty, protecting children online and must use effective age assurance to access content (UK Government, 2023). This raises ongoing operating costs and creates reputational risk if controls fail, so the business needs clear governance and documented safety processes. The startup may be eligible for UK innovation finance (UK Innovation Loans), but funding is competitive and uncertain (Innovate UK, 2025). There is large political scrutiny over algorithmic ranking systems determining the content being presented. Governments are therefore trying to regulate and reduce misinformation conforming to regulatory standards.

Economic

UK household budgets remain constrained by inflationary pressures creating caution about purchasing another subscription to price sensitive customers (House of Commons, 2026). UK consumers frequently cancel subscriptions and competition reduces customers' willingness to pay £2.99 for apps providing similar features. Customers are likely to cancel a minimum one service within 12 months, so pricing must stay simple and clearly justified (Barclays, 2025; YouGov, 2024). Opportunities involve yearly subscriptions providing businesses with stable income rather than ads which are economically unpredictable due to high volatility and changing algorithms. Nowadays customers are accustomed to having to purchase a subscription for any new service therefore it is not a surprise that this service will come at a cost as it is more exclusive rather than a saturated free app used by anyone. The community feature poses an opportunity and will help boost revenue as more people will talk about how easy it is to connect with others making them feel comfortable. This encourages more people to purchase the subscription.

Socio-cultural

Socio-cultural conditions support private social platforms centered on close connections. GEN Z Concerns show 45% worried over digital addiction with 87% having negative impacts on mental health. Interest in predictable, non-recommended feeds is visible in major platforms experimenting with friend-only experiences (Meta, 2025). However, new platforms face challenges as they have little value if existing friends don't adopt as many still value public performance metrics (views, likes). 68% of expats say it is difficult building a new social group therefore our community feature reduces this by connecting through activities and interest with others. Within society word of mouth has huge impacts on the popularity of new apps.

Technological

Products require safety-by-default engineering because abuse occurs through posts, private messaging. MVP priorities are account integrity and rate limiting, reporting, moderation, and messaging protections to reduce harassment and unwanted contact (Instagram, 2021; Discord, n.d.).

Next-stage priorities include automated filtering and review triage to scale enforcement (Reddit, 2026). UK compliance makes age assurance and children's access assessments central to onboarding and feature design (Ofcom, 2024). Low technological barriers allow large competitors to imitate apps using technology available to everyone. Moreover listing apps (app store, google play) involves commission to providers (15%-30%) reducing profit. Scalable cloud computing systems such as AWS are required to host the system providing a reliable service through secure data storage and performance reducing large investment. Technology is always improving especially in cybersecurity areas so protocols like encryption and authorisation are always up to date maximising security and our values. However due to rapid technological advancements newer software is being released meaning continuous updates have to be made.

Legal

Legal factors involve GDPR 2018 aligning with our app including data minimisation advocating for user privacy enhancing customers trust. This regulation ensures secure control over personal data and information. Not complying leads to fines and reputational damage. Complying with consumer rights act 2015 ensures platform is fit for purpose, increasing credibility and attracting new customers. compliance with DMCC act 2024 ensures clear subscription pricing and transparency

combatting subscription traps. We want to be transparent with our customers through clear pricing and no hidden costs. The copyright, design and patents act 1988 must be followed protecting original work such as images and literacy so our apps will need to be unique in design, colours and layout.

Environmental

Environmental factors involve established platforms relying on high electricity consumption through tools and software to collect data. High energy consumption data centres contribute 3% of global greenhouse gasses therefore eco-friendly options should be considered. Eco friendly hosting (cloud services) reduces carbon footprint. Finally when new apps launch this increases the number of new devices to run the app at its best performance however this contributes to e-waste whereby if devices are not discarded correctly it can lead to health problems and loss of valuable materials.

2.4. Additional Technique: Lean Canvas

Lean canvas was chosen because Link.ly is in the early stage and lean canvas shows how to make assumptions, and test them quickly to show a testable strategy.

Customers' top problems: 1) Algorithm-driven, privacy exploitation on ad-funded platforms 2) Fragmented connections during life transitions	Possible solutions for each problem: 1) Strict usage limits (1 post/day, 5/week) 2) Friend-only chronological feed	Unique Value Proposition: Stay close without noise by enabling real connection in a friend-first social space High-Level Concept: 2007 Facebook meets the loud and distracting digital age; WhatsApp/Messenger/Signal combined MeetUp, without algorithmic manipulation	Unfair Advantage: First UK-compliant minimalist platform following SpaceHey's withdrawal. Direct London university access for cost effective acquisition.	Customer Segments: UK students and young professionals experiencing relocation/study abroad; privacy conscious digital minimalists Early Adopters: Students studying abroad; remote workers relocating to new cities, digital detox/wellbeing community participants
Existing Alternatives: Meta/Facebook, MeWe, SpaceHey (not available in the UK)	Key Metrics: - renewal % - retention - average # of mutual connections after 7 days		Channels and path to customers (acquisition): University partnerships, wellbeing organisations, word-of-mouth within friend networks and digital minimalist communities	
Cost Structure: Costs include cloud infrastructure, age verification compliance, payment processing, marketing, and moderation			Revenue Structure: Monthly: £2.99. Annual: £23.88 (33% discount). Model: Direct subscription.	

2.5. Summary of Business Strategy

Based on the strategic analysis, a differentiation strategy is the best fit for Link.ly. Porter's Five Forces indicates high buyer power and strong substitutes because most social communication is already available for free, so Link.ly cannot compete on price or scale early on and competes on a distinct experience. The SWOT highlights that this positioning is a strength, but adoption is a weakness until

users build a friend network, therefore, early growth should prioritise small groups like university groups and relocation communities where mutual connections form quickly.

PESTEL analysis suggests a compliance approach, because stricter platform regulation and growing privacy expectations make trust and safety priorities. Technically, this strategy implies a phased rollout, where the first step would be to launch the website first to reduce dependency on mobile app-store fees and rules, prove retention and willingness-to-pay via trial-to-renewal, then expand to mobile once product-market fit is clearer. Success depends on disciplined scope like adding minimal features, strong security and anti-abuse measures, and clear subscription.

3. User requirements and System Design Specification

3.1. User Requirements

Functional Requirements

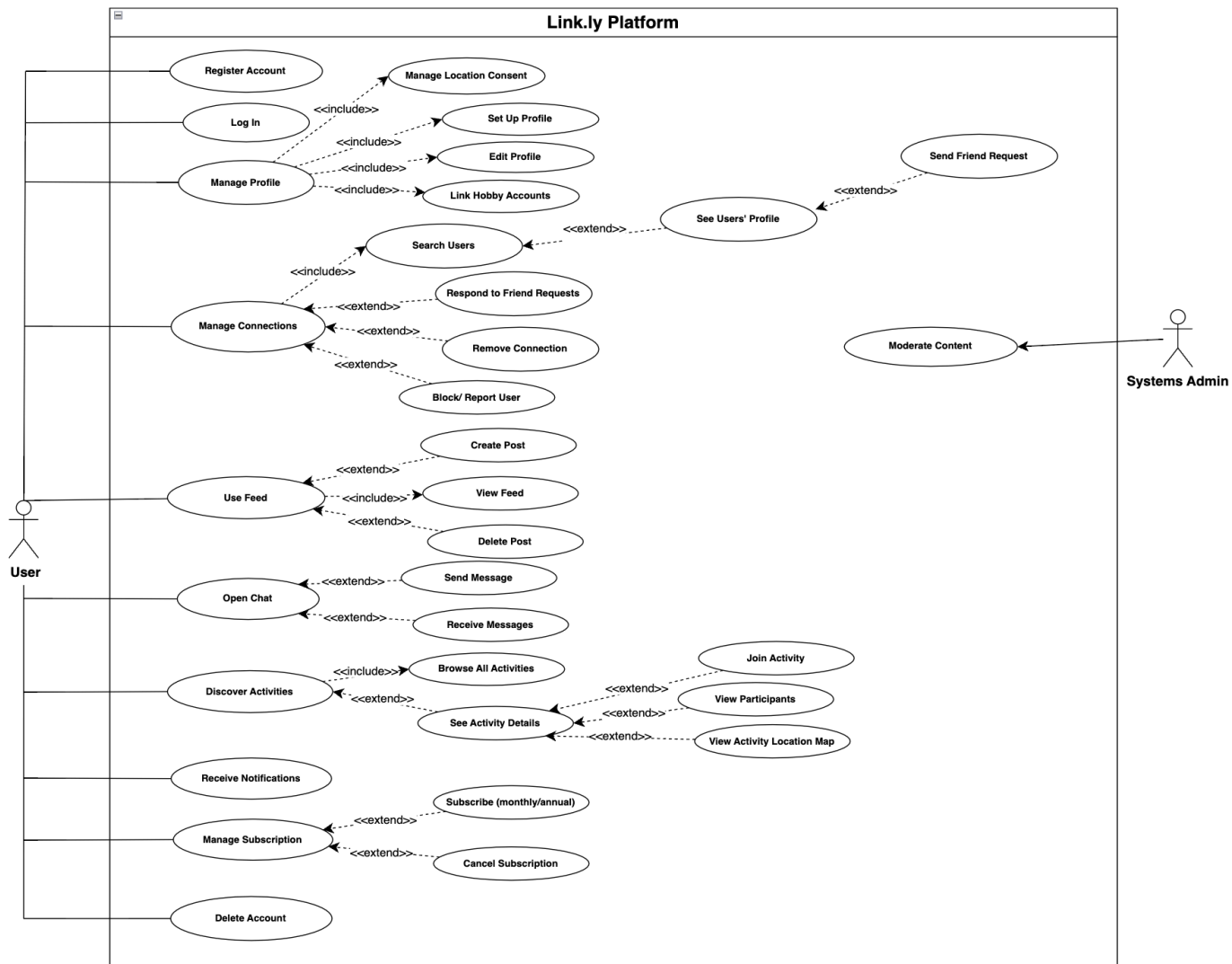
Functional Requirement	Use case mapping	Importance
Users must be able to create an account using an email address, phone number and password	Register Account	Critical
User must input their email address and password to log in	Log In	Critical
Users should be able to link other hobby accounts (Strava, Letterboxd, Goodreads, Duolingo, LinkedIn, Spotify etc.)	Link External Hobby Accounts	Low
Users must be able to set a display name, profile photo, date of birth, link hobby account and short bio during registration	Set Up Profile	Medium
Users must be able to search for other users by name, username	Search Users	High
Users must be able to send, accept, decline or cancel friend requests	Manage Connections	High
Users must be able to remove existing friends at any time	Remove Connection	Medium
The user must only be able to connect with others through mutual acceptance (no one-way following)	Manage Connections	High
Users must be able to create posts - either text only, media only or a mix of both	Create Post	High
Users must be limited to 1 post per day or 5 posts per week maximum	Create Post	High
The feed must only show content from friends (mutual connections)	View Feed	High
The system administrator must be able to review and remove content that violates the platform's content policy (e.g., advertising, spam, meme content, or influencer content).	Moderate Content	High
Once the user scrolls past all new posts, "you're all caught up" shows; no infinite scroll nor suggested content	View Feed	Low
Users must be able to delete their own posts at any time	Delete Post	Low

Users must be able to send direct text messages to any friend	Send Message	Medium
The user shall be able to message friends privately (one-to-one), with group chats added in a future release.	Send Message	Low
The user shall be able to view a map showing the location of activities.	View Activity Location Map	Low
Users must be able to join pre-defined activities in their city of choice	Join Activity	Medium
Users must be able to view the participants of an activity	View Participants	Medium
Users must be able to cancel or change their subscription plan from the account's settings	Manage Subscription	Critical
Users must be able to block or report other users	Block/Report User	Low
Users must be able to permanently delete their account and all associated data	Delete Account	High
Users must receive notifications for: new friend requests, new direct messages and replies to their posts	Receive Notifications	Medium

Non-Functional Requirements

Non-Functional Requirement	Importance
The platform must comply with GDPR (EU) and UK GDPR regulations	Critical
A clear privacy policy must be accessible when an account is created	Critical
The system must not share personal information to any 3-rd party	Critical
The system must not record user's location without their consent	Critical
All passwords and data transmitted must be encrypted	Critical
The system must also be available as a website	High
The feed must load within 2 seconds on a standard mobile connection	High
The platform must support up to 50,000 concurrent users without degradation in response time	High
The system must be able to run on all mobile operating systems	High

3.2. Use Case Diagram



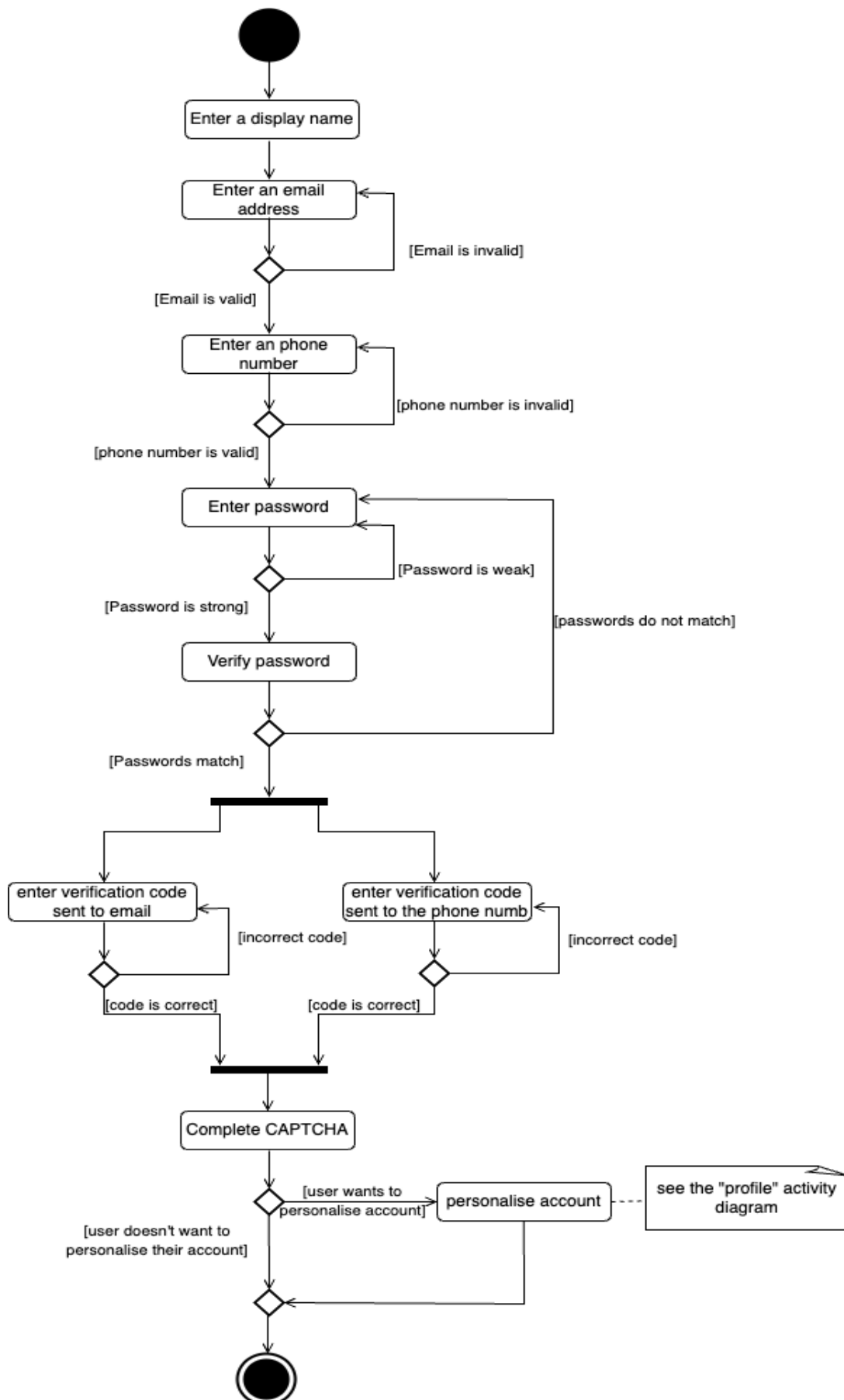
3.3. Use Case Description

Use Case Name	Use Feed/Create Post	
Brief Description	This use case description explains how a user creates and publishes a post that is visible exclusively to their mutual friends. The system enforces posting limits and content policies to maintain the platform's design.	
Actors	User	
Purpose	To allow a user to share content with mutual friends while enforcing platform rules regarding posting limits and content restrictions.	
Pre- conditions	- The user has an active subscription - The user has not exceeded the daily (1 post) or weekly (5 posts) quota. - The user is registered - The user is logged into the system	
Main Flow	Actor Action 1. The subscriber selects the "Create Post" option from the feed interface. 2. The subscriber enters text and/or uploads media and confirms submission.	System Response 2. The system displays the post creation interface, including remaining daily and weekly post quotas. 3. The system validates quota limits and checks content against prohibited categories (advertising, spam, influencer content, memes). 4. If validation is successful, the system publishes the post to mutual friends' feeds in strict chronological order. 5. The system displays posts exclusively from mutual connections and shows a "You're all caught up" message when no new posts remain.
Alternative Courses	- If the daily or weekly post limit is reached, the system prevents submission and displays an appropriate notification ("Quota Exceeded") - If automated filtering detects prohibited content, the system rejects the post and provides a reason. - The subscriber may delete their post at any time, triggering immediate removal from all friends' feeds and permanent deletion from system storage.	
Post- conditions	- The post is successfully published to mutual friends' feeds in chronological order, OR the post is rejected and not stored in the system. - If deleted, the post is permanently removed from all system records.	

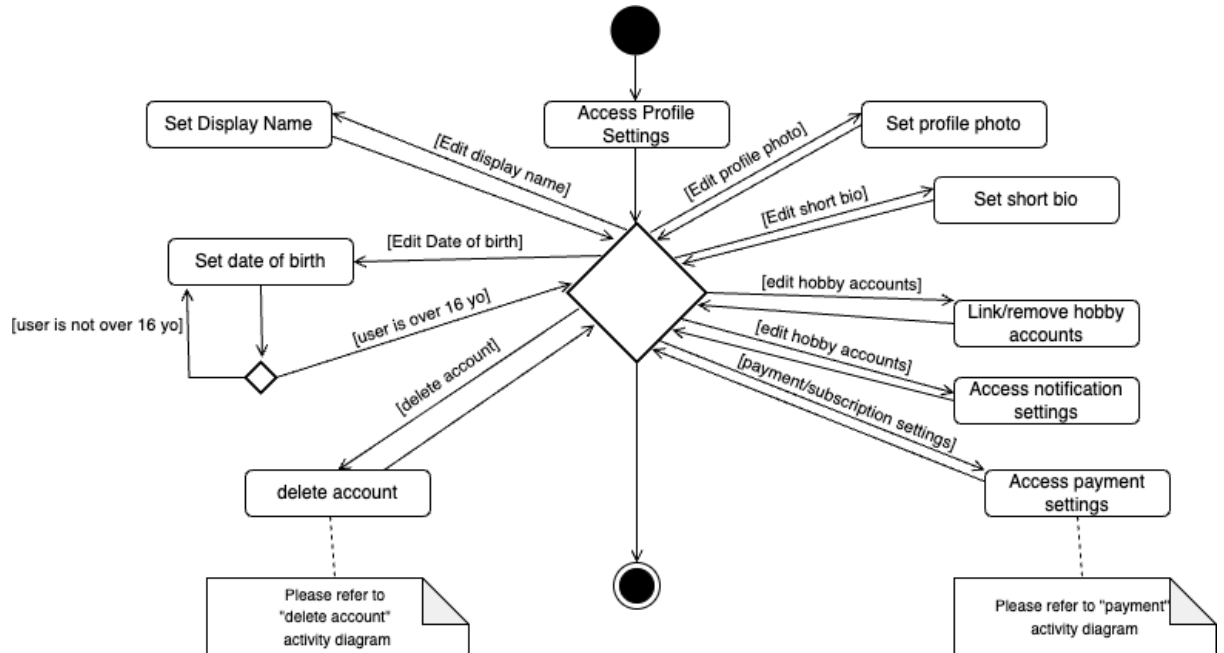
3.4. Additional Technique: Activity diagrams

Activity diagrams display how the system behaves and display the intended digital minimalism and non-addictive nature of the feed through which the users will scroll.

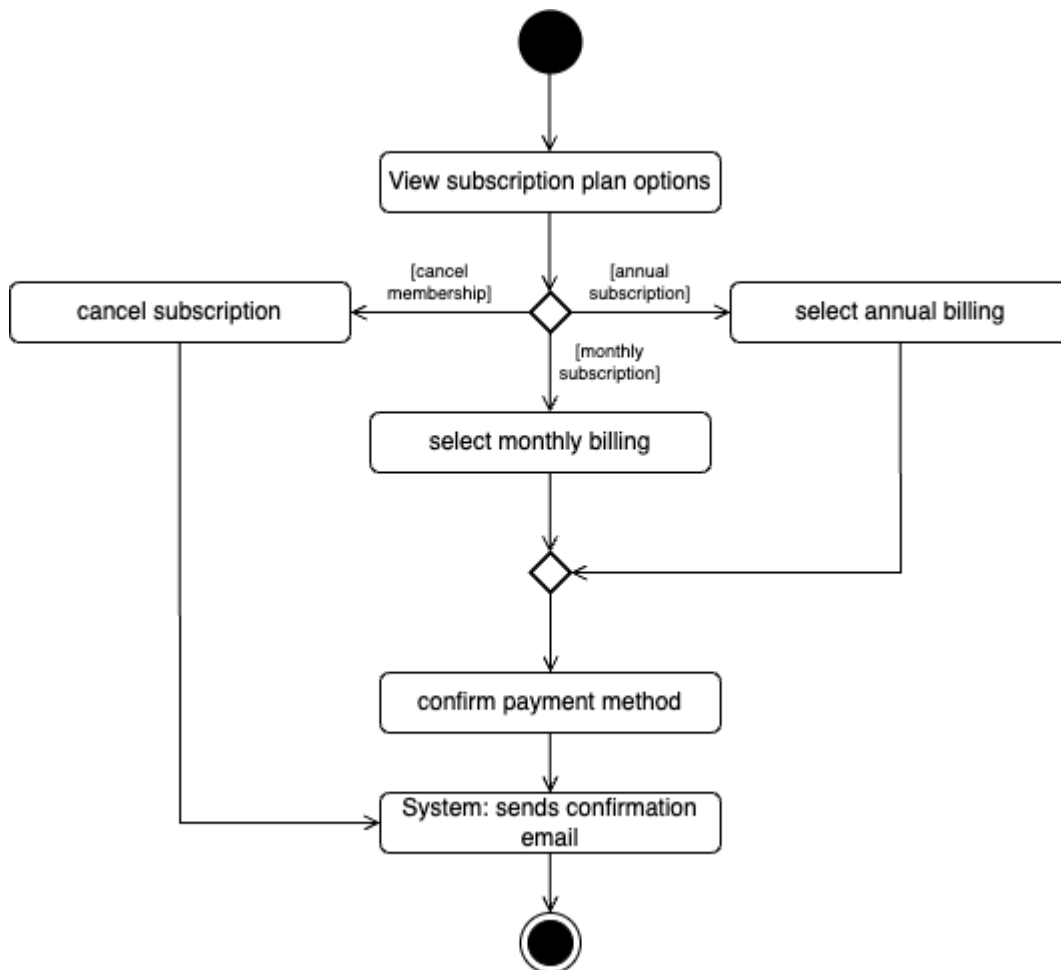
Activity Diagram for Register Account



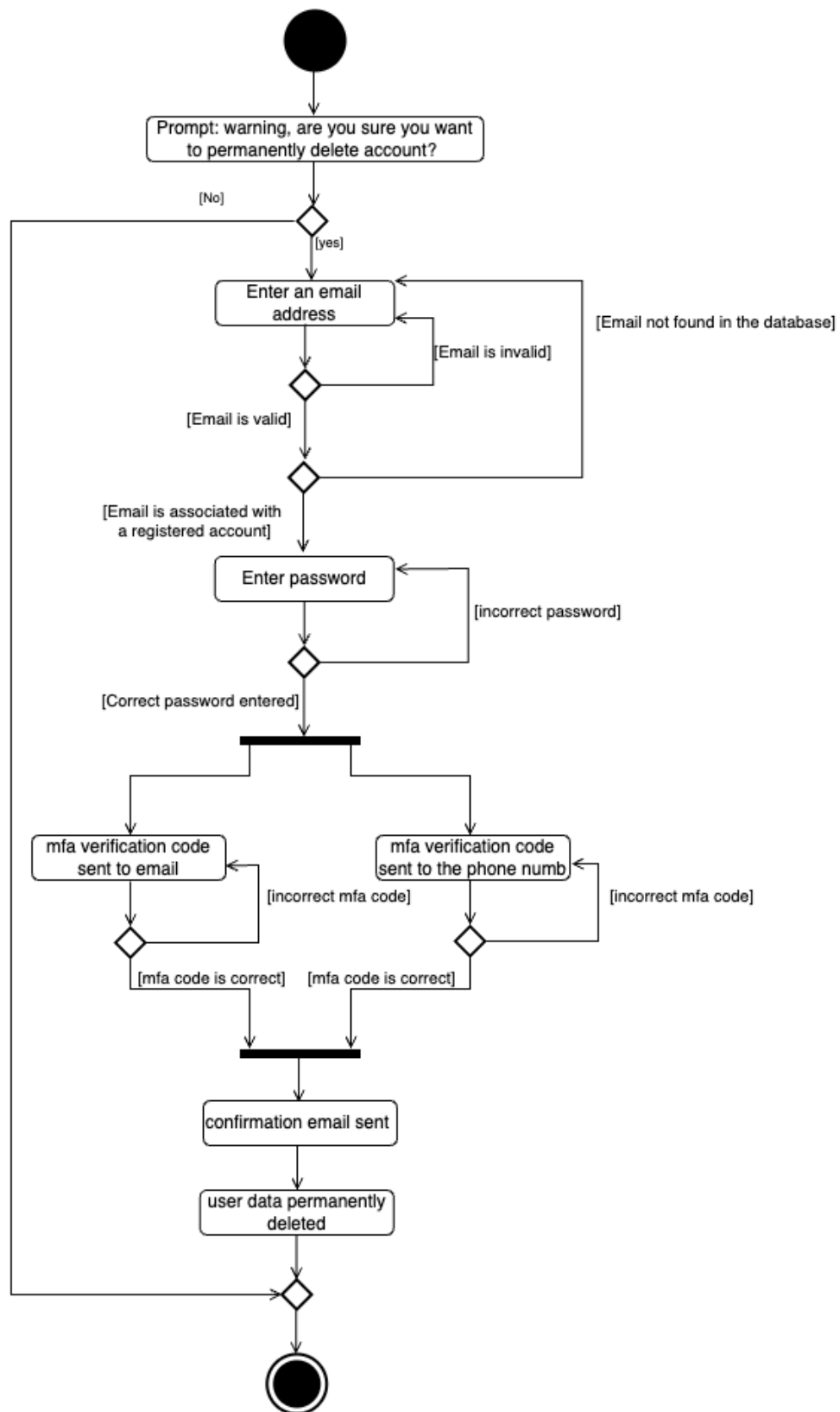
Activity Diagram for Manage Profile



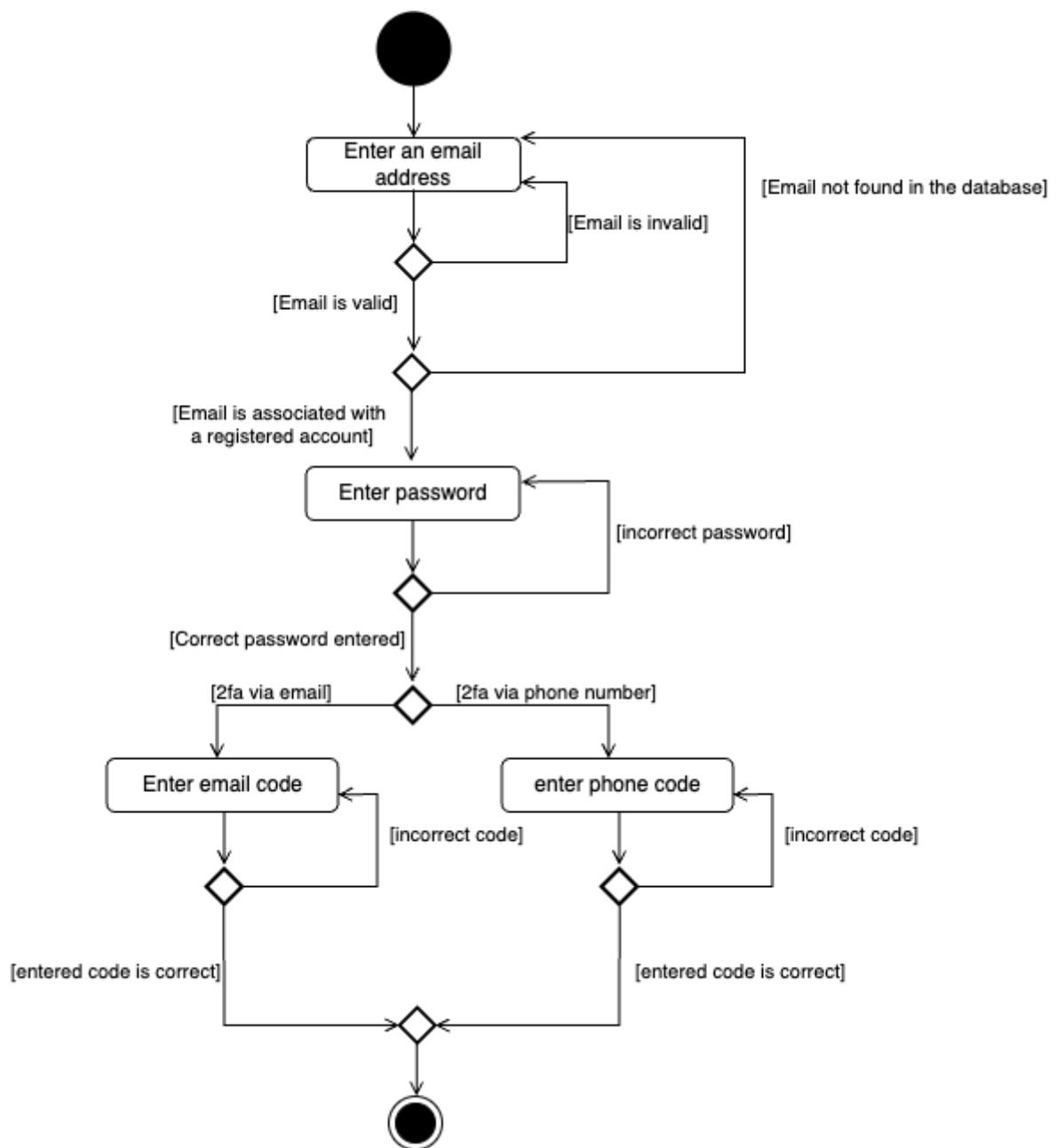
Activity Diagram for Manage Subscription



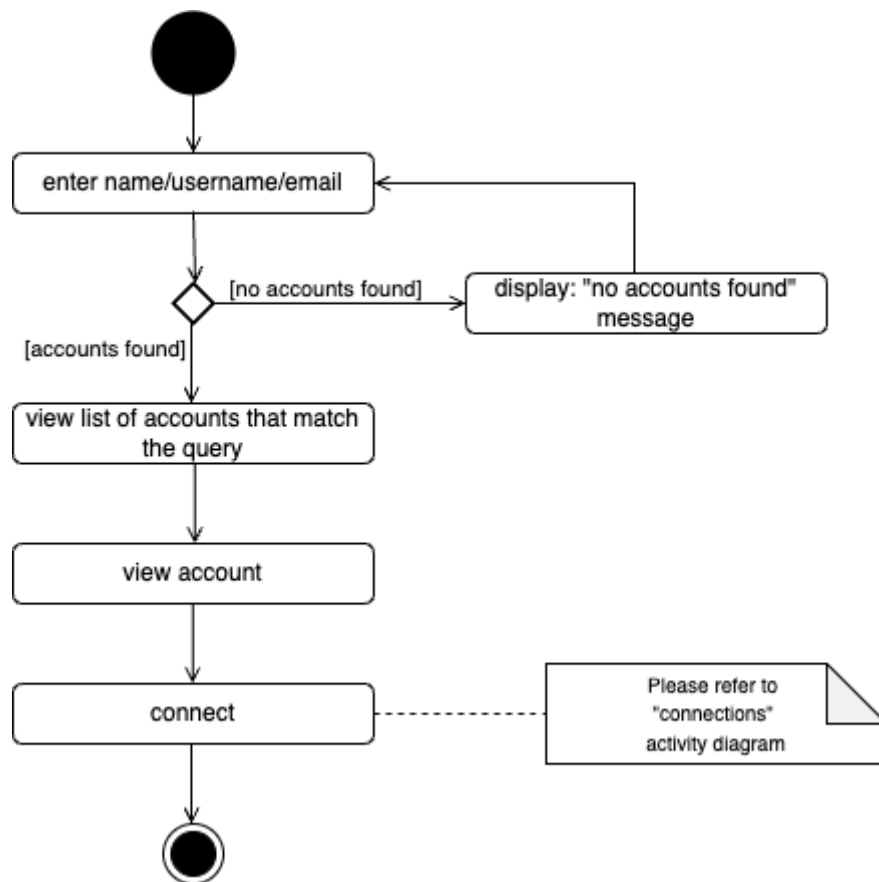
Activity Diagram for Manage Account



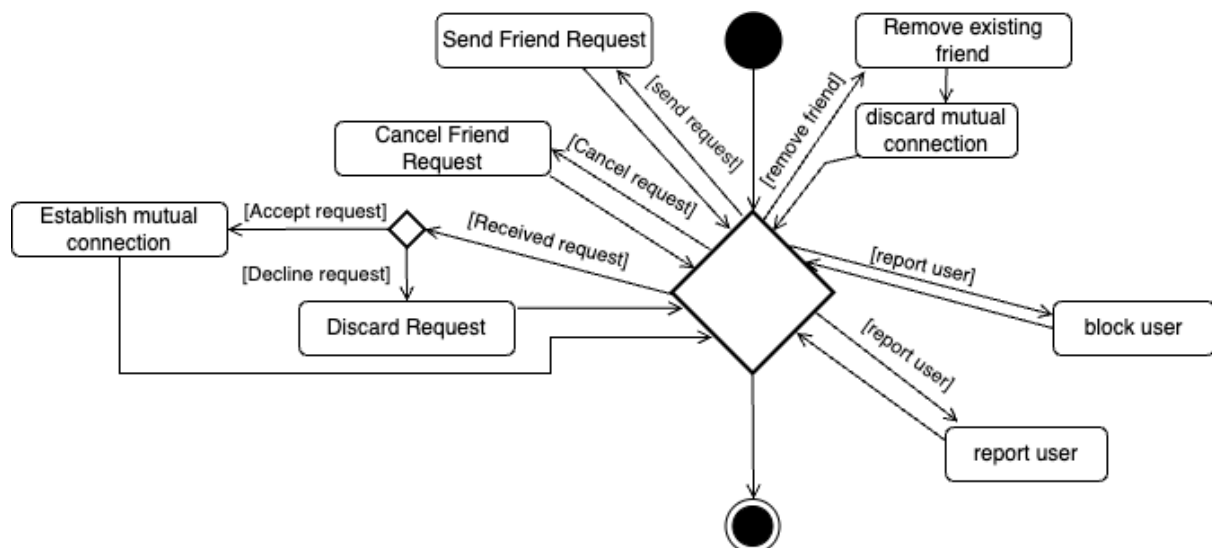
Activity Diagram for Login



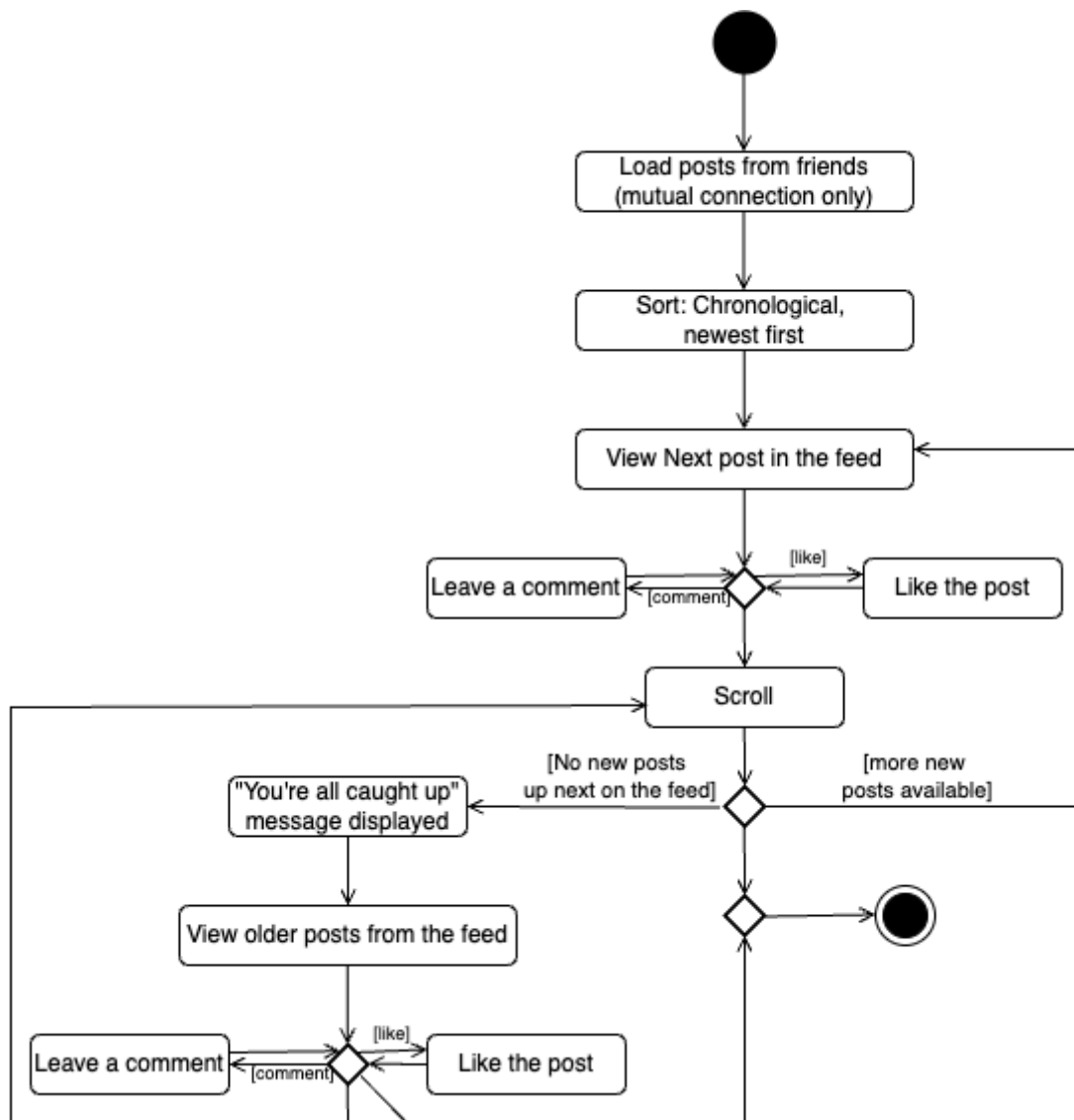
Activity Diagram for Search Users



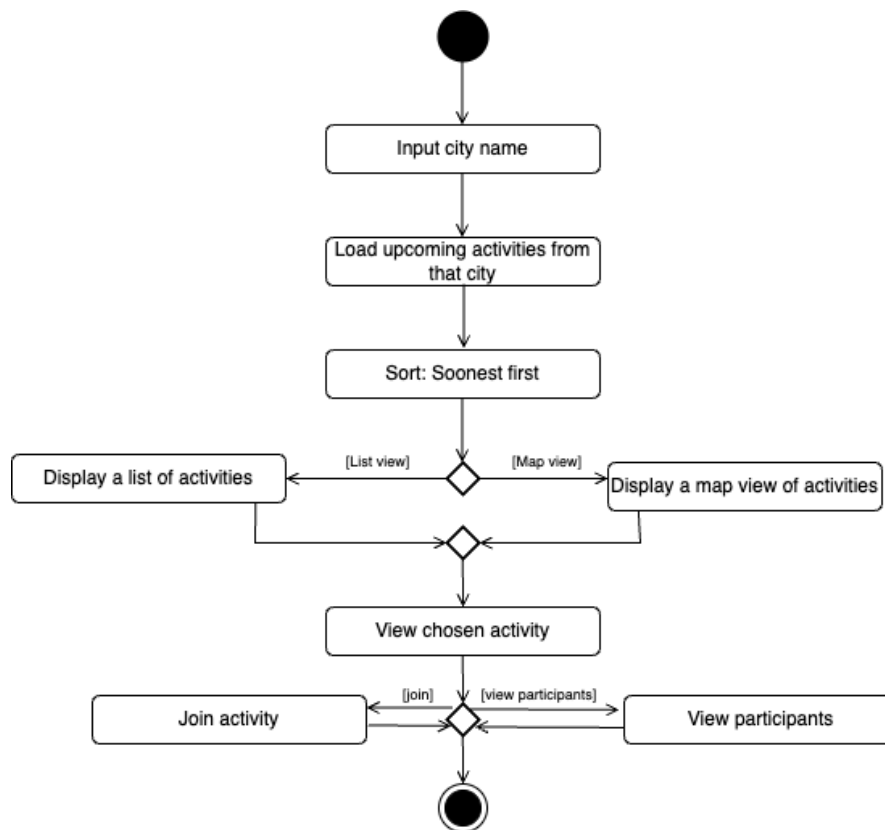
Activity Diagram for Manage Connections



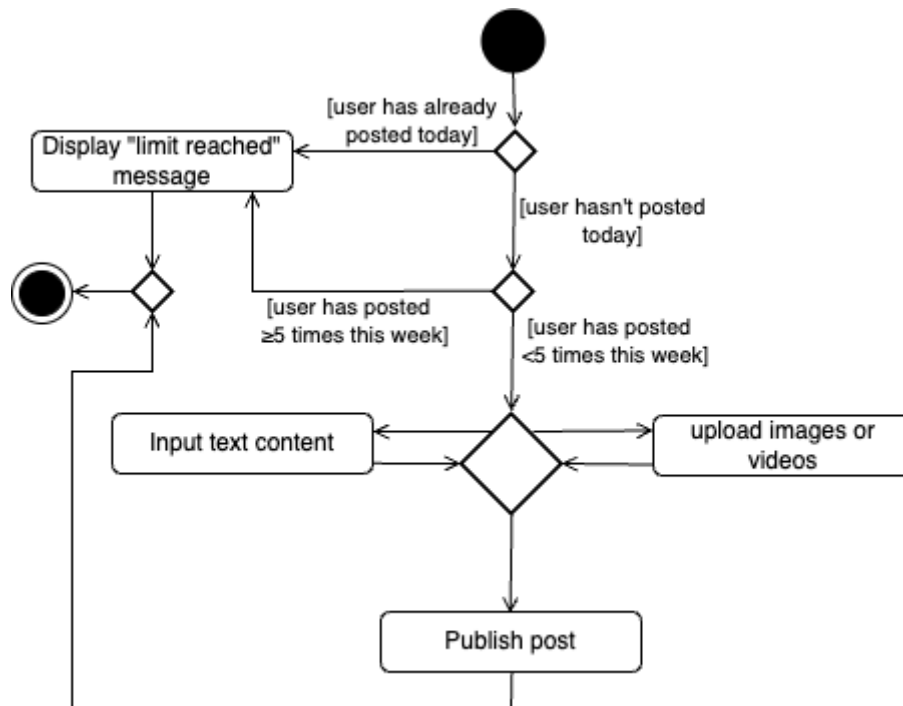
Activity Diagram for View Feed



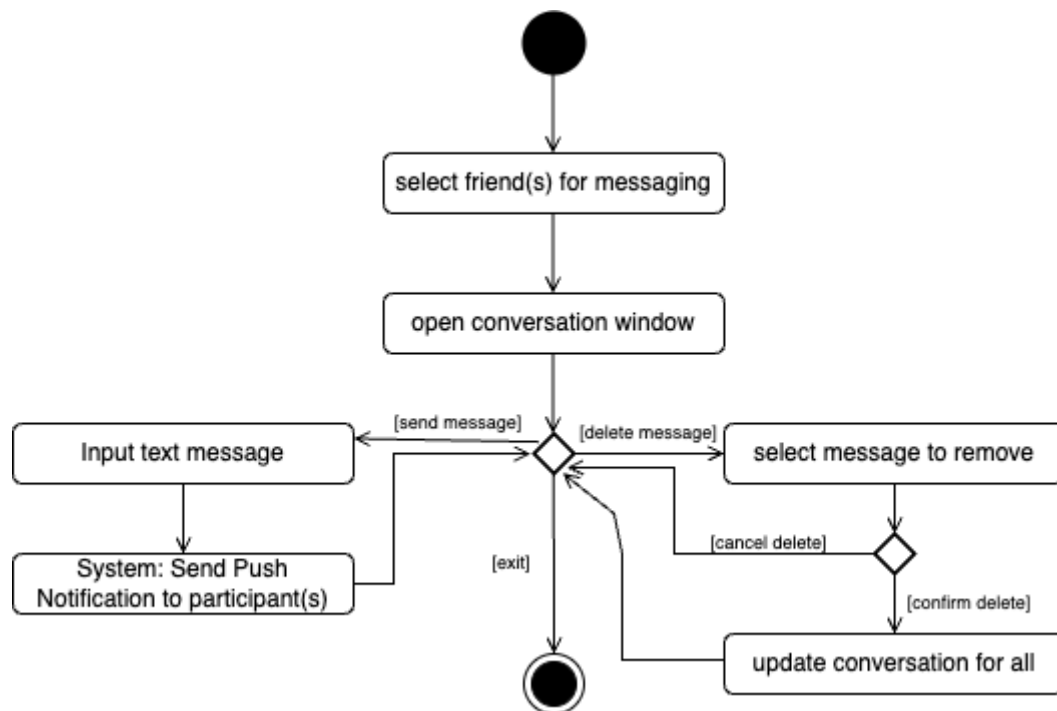
Activity Diagram for Manage Activities



Activity Diagram for Create & Manage Posts



Activity Diagram for Send Messages



4. Individual roles in the business, group mentoring – max 300 words (10 marks)

Eesa Batan

If our business was to launch my job role would be User experience and User interface lead. User experience ensures I provide customers with a positive experience through easy and intuitive functionality, whilst User interface ensures clear layout of elements so it's accessible for our target demographic through the use of trustworthy colours and design aligning with our values of digital minimalism and privacy.

I would be suitable for this role because of knowledge acquired from the corporate world and web design modules. I fully understand specific needs from user requirements as well as knowledge from contributing to different strategic analysis techniques which influence my decision making.

My role is important in achieving strategic goals as our differentiation focuses on creating a simplistic and intuitive digital minimalistic app. If our interface design is not appealing or complex to use this contradicts our positioning, further deterring customers from the app.

The group mentoring sessions were useful as in the first meeting the mentor helped to focus on our value proposition specifically (digital minimalism) rather than trying to cover all aspects such as communities and postings. This was valuable as without this advice our app could potentially be seen as a poor competitor to existing apps. However with her advice on potential ways in which we could market our product such as universities this has helped to strengthen our position in a crowded market allowing us to succeed. In the second meeting another mentor provided feedback by mentioning our work didn't always link well across tasks for example pricing being an issue but how

we would combat this so both customer and company benefit. Therefore this was the best piece of advice as clear alignment enhances professionalism which overall strengthens the positioning of our app to achieve a desired goal.

Sri Ganesan

As CFO and Investment Strategy Lead of link.ly, my main responsibility would be to ensure the long-term sustainability of the platform. Some of my main responsibilities include developing the pricing model, forecasting revenue, estimating all the operational costs, and analysing the breakeven points. I would also be assessing the funding options such as innovation grants from the UK government or an early stage investment and prepare the financial projections for the potential investors.

I am suitable for this role because I contributed to the revenue model, pricing justification, and parts of the strategic analysis such as SWOT and PESTLE. These frameworks helped me understand the economic pressures affecting subscription businesses in the UK and the risks linked to price sensitive consumers. As identified in Porter's Five Forces, buyer power is high and substitutes are free, so my role is critical in balancing affordability with sustainability. Without careful financial planning, even a strong concept could fail due to cash flow problems or unrealistic growth expectations.

My role directly supports our differentiation strategy. Since we are subscription-funded rather than ad-funded, financial discipline is essential. Clear pricing, transparent subscription management, and compliance with regulations such as the DMCC Act strengthen trust and reduce risk of bankruptcy.

Pawel Krezel

If our company were to launch, I would happily undertake the role of a Backend Engineer with particular focus on bot and spam prevention. As a Computer Science student with passion for web development and my final year project utilising the Django framework, I have acquired a backend focused skillset which I would like to further work on. My responsibilities at the aforementioned role would include designing, scaling and maintaining the database, enforcing best practices related to cybersecurity and ensuring that the functional requirements are implemented and working correctly.

Additionally I would like to design mechanisms and policies that detect undesired user activity, especially related to posting spam content and intercepting bot activity. I believe such mechanisms and policies would be necessary for our platform as the company's perceived value and advantage over modern day social media comes from the ethos of digital minimalism and a distraction-free feed which encourages genuine social connection via social media and discourages so-called "doomscrolling". Therefore spam such as memes, so-called "rage-bait" content, celebrities posting to a wider audience or businesses trying to advertise their products and services through short-form videos would not be allowed on our platform.

Group mentoring sessions taught me how to pitch the business idea more effectively. The first session for our group lasted approximately one hour and was with Ms Dami Lawal. During that session I realised that the business idea may be popular not only with members of Generation Z, but

also Millennials. When discussing the business idea, Ms Lawal used the term "Digital Fatigue" which resonated with me. The feedback she gave us guided our strategy for generating revenue which is a subscription based model which must be inexpensive - cost less than a cup of coffee and generate revenue through the economies of scale.

Alexandra Marin

As CTO and Product Lead for Link.ly, my role would be to be the bridge between technical execution and product vision, ensuring the platform's architecture and features match digital-minimalist values. I would be responsible for overseeing the development of a secure, scalable system that delivers a chronological friend-only feed, and implements privacy protections including end-to-end encryption and GDPR-compliant data handling. My suitability for this role is the high background in Computer Science, cryptanalysis projects combined with management skills developed overtime after being the lead in group projects and being involved in business courses.

The group mentoring sessions significantly shaped my approach to both product development and our overall strategy. In our first session, the mentor validated our core concept while pushing us to focus on digital minimalism and to refine our target audience and moving beyond just Gen Z to include millennials as well. This influenced how I prioritised features like the activities discovery tool for new city residents. In the second mentoring session, we had to pitch our idea to a completely new mentor that did not know us from previous meetings. She provided the most impactful advice by challenging our initial pricing assumptions, helping us reduce the subscription cost to £2.99 monthly while maintaining the annual discount structure. The key takeaway for me was that a good idea is not just about the pitch. It is about continuously refining it based on feedback and what users actually need.

Brenda Ojatamm

If Link.ly launched, I would act as CEO while leading Operations and Customer Support, serving as the team's decision-holder and coordinator. I was appointed CEO *without prior experience*, but I enjoy entrepreneurship and I'm convinced a good team makes the learning curve manageable. My role would also be to protect our core priorities (trust, safety, and subscription value) so the platform grows without compromising its promise. I'm suitable because I have 5+ years of professional experience dealing with people, processes, and problems.

The mentoring sessions shaped the coursework by forcing realism and strengthening our justification. In the first session, the mentor pointed out we hadn't properly considered funding and sustainability because the idea came from personal experience and wanting better communication with loved ones. That feedback pushed us to take monetisation seriously and led us to a paid monthly/annual fee, which fits our values because it rewards user trust and satisfaction rather than maximising engagement for ads. After mentor feedback, we changed pricing to £2.99 and introduced annual discount, we also moved age assurance into onboarding requirements. The biggest takeaway was to watch The Apprentice critically to study pitching and see how people prepare, structure delivery (and sometimes mess up), so we could improve our own pitch performance.

Ryan Rahman

If our digital-minimalist social platform were to progress into a full venture, I would take on the role of Community & Partnerships Lead. My focus would be on building an authentic, engaged user community and forming meaningful partnerships with universities, local organisations, and interest-based groups that naturally align with our “friend-first, minimal social” ethos.

This role sits at the heart of our long-term strategy: our platform only succeeds if users feel genuinely connected, valued, and part of a trustworthy environment. My strengths in communication, relationship-building, and understanding social dynamics position me well for this responsibility. I’m particularly drawn to the idea of shaping a community that grows intentionally rather than through noise or algorithmic manipulation. By nurturing partnerships and supporting community-led initiatives, I would directly contribute to sustainable growth, strong user retention, and a credible platform reputation.

The group mentoring sessions played a significant role in shaping how I now think about both the business and technical direction of our platform. The session on 02/02/2026 was especially impactful, it pushed us to define our target audience with far more precision and to articulate what truly differentiates us in a crowded digital landscape.

One piece of advice that stayed with me was the emphasis on prioritising user experience over rapid feature expansion. Initially, I assumed that adding more functionality would strengthen our value proposition, but the mentoring helped me realise that simplicity is not just a design choice for us — it’s the foundation of our entire concept. This shifted how I think about community engagement and partnerships: every decision should reinforce a calm, intentional, and meaningful user experience. That perspective has become central to how I see my role and the direction of the platform as a whole.

Appendix

Records of collaboration and discussions

Date & Time	Absent Members	Items Discussed and Decided
26.01 14:00- 16:00	-	Deciding on channels for documentation and communication. WhatsApp will be used for communication, Google Docs/ Word will be used for collaborative work.
02.02 14:00-15:00	-	Review and discussion on coursework specification, agreeing on the business and role for each member.
09.02 14:00-15:00	Brenda	Decision on business name and division of tasks, working on the pitch, consumer research, Porter’s 5 Forces and others. Deciding on the roles group members would take if the business was to happen.
16.02 14:00-15:00	Sri	Next steps to take for the groupwork, decision to come up with a finalised draft for the final document, further discussing the business model and the key frameworks to use. Discussion with 2 mentors who enjoyed the business as an idea, giving us further feedback to think about marketing and how to acquire people.

23.02 11:00-12:00		Discussion on work that's been done so far, what's left and how we'll continue to finish the group work successfully.
28.02 10:00-11:00	Brenda	Individual parts finished by Tuesday, finish formatting, aim to submit by Wednesday night (4th March) before the deadline on 5th.
02.03 14:00-16:00	-	Showcasing the report to lecturers, questions about report and getting feedback on the work so far.

AI Declaration

We confirm that we have not used AI to generate content that we are presenting as our own work, and we remain fully responsible for the ideas, analysis, and conclusions in this submission. ChatGPT was used for language support like rewriting and polishing sentences to improve clarity, readability, and structure.

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